



Self-drilling robot

NASA has a prototype robot VALKYRIE, which would be able to burrow through sheets of ice on alien planets on its own <http://dgit.in/VALKYRIEBot>

Drone no-fly zones

With drones becoming popular, there are certain no-fly zones for them and Mapbox tells you where <http://dgit.in/Mapbox>

Space Age

flaps that astronauts can use to dock themselves to a partner with a similar suit, to prevent their partner from floating away. Once the two lovebirds are locked in, they can proceed with the docking procedure without fear.

Vanna Bonta, the inventor, tested the 2suit with her husband in 2008 in a Boeing flight that simulated weightlessness. The suit did help the couple stay together long enough to get cosy, but it did not prevent them from floating or spinning around as one unit. This means a 2suit would also need to be harnessed to something immovable – even more bondage for the already bonded... What we've learned thus far is that sexual intercourse in space is going to be very uncomfortable.

Motion sickness has always been a problem in space, so that's going to add complexity to any moves you try. Also, despite all this talk of absolute zero temperatures, actually life in space is a hotter and sweatier affair than Earth already. This is because there's no natural convection to remove the excess heat from bodies. Start doing more physical activity, and double the body heat that will be generated during fornication, and you're literally screwed!

If that was not enough, the sweat you release could build up and float off as droplets that could be harmful for equipment. The same goes for all the bodily fluids you might eject.

If your spaceship could have artificial or simulated gravity, it would make things much more comfortable, and thus we assume most space farers will insist on this. The best that current technology has to offer is a centrifuge inside your spaceship – a giant rotating ring that creates a cen-

tripetal force, allowing you to experience a kind of gravity. It does not compare to the full gravitational field on the Starship Enterprise, but beggars cannot be choosers.

Fledgling concerns

If your mind is now ready to arise from the gutter, let's consider the need for procreating the species, such as when travelling on a thousand year journey to go off and colonise a distant planet. This would require space conception, and that comes with a harem of challenges of its own.

For starters, the micro gravity environment of space means that the flow of bodily fluids is haywire, and eggs might not end up in the right place, and even if they do, they may not be fertilised because the spermatozoa literally don't know which way is up!

There has never been a full cycle of first generation reproduction in space, not even for animals, primarily because it has been too difficult for scientists to build animal enclosures to support this. The closest we got to this was an experiment with rats during the 1995 space shuttle mission. The rats were able to copulate in space, but the offspring of space and non-space hybrids showed retarded growth and abnormalities. The rats that gave birth after being in space had fewer contractions, which led to lower hormonal release and delayed development.

However, rats are not accurate models, since they mature quicker and aren't affected by gravity in the same way as we are. We first need to test larger mammals before conducting human trials. We know that gravity plays a larger role in embryonic development only later in the pregnancy term. As the fetus develops, it

is initially buoyant but eventually needs to be exposed to gravity to be normal, or the skeletal structure can be damaged.

Human babies that were born in space would have underdeveloped fetal skeletons and compromised immune functions. Also, the formation of neural connections might be hampered, as that too requires gravity.

Radiation is another challenge. Up in space, outside the protective shield of Earth's atmosphere radiation can cause sterility, cancer, miscarriages and also affect fetal development. Cells would either not replicate, or replicate in abnormal ways. The current breed of spaceships don't have adequate shielding for this.

There is also calcium deficiency, and loss of body and bone mass. Even with regular exercise to prevent muscle atrophy and loss of bone mass, astronauts still experience 15-20 per cent bone loss after six months in space, and so would any children they had.

So can we do it?

Yes, with some difficulty, and we know we'd want to, even if it was messy and difficult. Put a group of people in any scenario and they will eventually want to hook up. We will need to plan ahead, invent new drugs and medical techniques and find ways to keep people healthy despite all that we've spoken of before this. More research is needed, and more research will be done. Although NASA and other space organisations have not conducted human space sexuality or reproduction studies yet, they will eventually. One thing is for sure; the first baby to be either conceived or born in space will certainly be famous. 



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